

The Information Daily Briefing — 2026-08-12

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Coverage window: the last ~24 hours of The Information (editions dated 11 August 2026, US time). Prepared for SC, ~09:00 GMT+8, 12 August 2026.

Executive Summary

The last 24 hours were dominated by a single theme: **the financing engine behind the AI build-out is being wired directly into Wall Street's balance sheet, even as the economics of the companies doing the building look increasingly strained.** Nvidia unveiled a preliminary \$500 billion financing alliance with six of the largest private-capital firms and signalled it may *backstop up to a quarter* of each project — a striking move that blurs the line between chip vendor, lender and guarantor. On the same day, Anthropic launched a data-centre joint venture with Macquarie and Singapore's GIC, and OpenAI closed a \$7 billion employee tender at its \$852 billion valuation. Capital is flooding in at historic scale.

Against that, the operating numbers underneath told a more sobering story. Neocloud bellwether **CoreWeave** grew revenue 112% but burned \$5.7 billion of cash, leaning on an “adjusted EBITDA” figure that The Briefing dismantled as “nonsensical” for a company carrying this much depreciation and interest. Prediction-market **Kalshi** doubled annualised revenue to \$4 billion yet is raising for a *third* time in eight months, hinting it is still barely profitable. Enterprise-software incumbents are being pressured from two sides — the USDA is trimming its Salesforce footprint in favour of C3 AI and Palantir, and **Monday.com** guided to a sharp Q3 growth slowdown with net revenue retention slipping.

Overall sentiment: constructive-but-nervous. Equity markets are still rewarding top-line growth (CoreWeave +13% after hours; Intel up 175% over 12 months as it raises \$15 billion), but under the surface investors are beginning to scrutinise cash burn, vendor-financing circularity, credit risk at Nvidia, and where AI is a genuine share-gainer versus a margin threat. The open-source arms race intensified — Nvidia (Nemotron 4) and Meta (Muse Spark 1.2 / Muse Glimmer) both pushed further into open models, partly as a US-vs-China strategic play.

Key Stories — What / Why / When / Which / How

1. Nvidia lines up a \$500B AI-infrastructure financing alliance — and may backstop 25%

- **What:** A group of private-capital giants signed a *preliminary* agreement with Nvidia to raise **\$500 billion** to finance AI infrastructure (GPU racks and data centres). Nvidia has an option to **backstop up to 25%** of the financing on any project in the partnership.
- **Why:** The structure lets AI companies borrow more — and at lower rates — by having Nvidia effectively de-risk leases (co-signing, lease-backs, or buy-back guarantees of compute at a base rate). It is the clearest sign yet that GPU demand is now being underwritten by the vendor itself, which both accelerates the build-out and concentrates risk on Nvidia's balance sheet.
- **When:** Announced Monday, 10 Aug; reported in The Information AM on 11 Aug. Not yet finalised.
- **Which:** Nvidia (NVDA); lenders Apollo (APO), BlackRock (BLK), Blackstone (BX), Brookfield (BN), Goldman Sachs (GS), KKR (KKR); indirect beneficiary OpenAI (private, potential 10GW Ohio tenant).
- **How:** All “third-party capital,” per Nvidia. Backstops mirror tools Nvidia already uses with OpenAI and neoclouds. Some investors have flagged Nvidia credit-risk concerns despite ~\$50B quarterly free cash flow.
- **Link:** [Nvidia May Backstop Up To 25% Of Projects From \\$500B Alliance](#)

2. CoreWeave's “red ink”: 112% revenue growth, \$5.7B cash burn

- **What:** CoreWeave reported Q2 revenue up **112% to \$2.575B**, but **cash burn rose ~112% to \$5.7B**. “Adjusted EBITDA” doubled to \$1.5B — a metric The Briefing called nonsensical given D&A more than doubled to \$1.39B and interest costs rose 140% to \$640M.
- **Why:** It crystallises the core neocloud question — can a highly leveraged, depreciation-heavy compute-rental model ever throw off real free cash flow? Investors currently reward growth and adjusted EBITDA over GAAP profitability.
- **When:** Q2 results reported Tuesday, 10 Aug; stock +13% after hours.
- **Which:** CoreWeave (CRWV); read-through to neocloud peers and to Nvidia (NVDA) demand.
- **How:** Cash burn mostly reflects data-centre capex, which should eventually decline — but ongoing maintenance, chip upgrades and interest make the steady-state margin unknowable for now.
- **Link:** [The Briefing: CoreWeave's Red Ink](#)

3. Kalshi's annualised revenue doubles to \$4B; eyeing a \$40B valuation

- **What:** World Cup wagers helped **double Kalshi's annualised revenue to >\$4B in July** (from >\$2B two months earlier — i.e. ~\$333M monthly). It is in advanced talks to raise at a **\$40B valuation**, nearly double its May round.

- **Why:** Explosive growth, but June operating expenses hit ~\$300M (heavy marketing), and Kalshi is raising for the third time in eight months — suggesting it is still barely profitable. Potential new state taxes loom on its biggest markets.
- **When:** Scooped by The Information on Tuesday, 11 Aug.
- **Which:** Kalshi (private); competitive read-through to Polymarket, DraftKings (DKNG), Flutter/FanDuel (FLUT), Robinhood (HOOD, prediction-markets ambitions).
- **How:** Growth via event-driven betting (sports/World Cup) plus aggressive customer-acquisition spend; valuation rises each round even as it keeps returning to market for capital.
- **Link:** [Kalshi Tops \\$4 Billion In Annualized Revenue as it Seeks \\$40B Valuation](#)

4. OpenAI: real growth, real strain underneath

- **What:** ChatGPT is **nearing 1 billion weekly active users**; the “Astra” flagship was previewed to DC regulators, then **paused over cyber concerns**; employees sold **\$7B in a tender** at the \$852B valuation (total secondary sales now ~\$16B); COO-adjacent exec Brad Lightcap is leaving; a robotics lead defected to Anthropic; and Apple/OpenAI litigation continues.
- **Why:** The cluster doubles as a stress test of OpenAI’s IPO-track thesis: the growth engine is accelerating (Codex gaining on Claude Code; CFO says revenue growth re-accelerated in July) while governance, safety, security and talent-retention cracks widen.
- **When:** Multiple items across 10–11 Aug.
- **Which:** OpenAI (private); Anthropic (private); Apple (AAPL); Microsoft (MSFT) and Amazon (AMZN, which just completed an added \$35B investment) as backers/compute partners.
- **How:** Scale funded by mega-rounds and vendor financing; the same scale amplifies security, regulatory and organisational fragility ahead of an expected IPO.
- **Link:** [OpenAI’s ChatGPT Nears 1B Weekly Users](#) · [OpenAI Pauses Astra on Cyber Concerns](#) · [OpenAI Employees Sell \\$7B in Tender](#)

5. Nvidia doubles down on its own open-source models (Nemotron 4)

- **What:** Nvidia is investing heavily in an ambitious in-house model family, **Nemotron 4**, aiming to match the world’s best open-source models — but which could **compete with its own customers and partners**.
- **Why:** Better open models drive demand for Nvidia hardware and deepen its platform moat; the risk is channel conflict with model-maker customers (OpenAI, Anthropic, Meta, neoclouds) who buy its GPUs.
- **When:** Exclusive published 11 Aug.
- **Which:** Nvidia (NVDA); competitive read-through to Meta (META), Alibaba (BABA, Qwen), Moonshot (Kimi), and closed-model labs.
- **How:** A very large research effort (its prior model paper had 570 authors; Nemotron 4 involves even more), signalling strategic priority.
- **Link:** [Why Nvidia Is Trying To Develop The World’s Best Open-Source AI Models](#)

6. Anthropic forms “Theseus” data-centre JV with Macquarie and GIC

- **What:** Anthropic, Macquarie Asset Management and Singapore’s **GIC** launched a new entity, **Theseus Infrastructure**, to develop, operate and lease AI data centres dedicated to Claude.
- **Why:** Anthropic is racing to secure ~10GW of compute over several years (cost in the hundreds of billions). Off-balance-sheet, sovereign-backed financing spreads the capex and de-risks Anthropic’s build-out ahead of a possible IPO.
- **When:** Announced Monday, 10 Aug.
- **Which:** Anthropic (private); Macquarie (MQG.AX); GIC (Singapore SWF); read-through to Nvidia (NVDA) demand and to power/utility suppliers.
- **How:** Macquarie/GIC funds own the platform and fund most of the equity per project; Anthropic covers consumer electricity-price increases. Initial US focus, sites TBD.
- **Link:** [Anthropic in New Datacenter Partnership With Macquarie, GIC](#)

7. Meta open-sources flagship Muse Spark 1.2 (and a laptop-sized Muse Glimmer)

- **What:** Meta will release an **open-weight version of Muse Spark 1.2** and a new small **Muse Glimmer** (30B params) that runs on a single consumer GPU/Mac. Zuckerberg urged Washington to cut “friction” on US open-source training data.
- **Why:** Provides US customers an alternative to Chinese open models (Qwen, Kimi) for national-security reasons and reasserts Meta’s open-source leadership; also a policy lobbying push. Muse Spark 1.2 currently ranks 7th on the Artificial Analysis index (behind Anthropic, OpenAI, Kimi K3, Qwen3.8 Max).
- **When:** Announced 11 Aug.
- **Which:** Meta (META); competitive pressure on Alibaba (BABA), Moonshot, and closed labs; tailwind for on-device/edge silicon.
- **How:** Open-weight release + governance change giving Meta’s board approval over model-release safety criteria.
- **Link:** [Meta to Open-Source Flagship Muse Spark 1.2 · Zuckerberg Calls on U.S. to Reduce Open-Source Friction](#)

8. Intel raises \$15B in a stock offering to fund expansion

- **What:** Intel is raising **\$15 billion** in a public stock offering, capitalising on a huge sentiment recovery (stock **+175% over 12 months**; shares -4% Monday on dilution).
- **Why:** Funds a nascent turnaround under CEO Lip-Bu Tan (Q2 revenue +25%, best growth in 15 years, driven by +59% in Data Center & AI). Intel benefits from a CPU shortage and gains traction in advanced packaging.
- **When:** Announced Monday, 10 Aug.
- **Which:** Intel (INTC); competitive read-through to TSMC (TSM), Nvidia (NVDA), AMD (AMD).
- **How:** Proceeds to fund “physical AI,” purpose-built silicon and advanced packaging; part of a record year of US equity issuance.
- **Link:** [Intel to Raise \\$15 Billion in a Stock Offering](#)

9. Enterprise software squeezed: USDA trims Salesforce for C3 AI/Palantir; Monday.com guides down

- **What:** The **USDA** (~\$3B/yr IT spend) let a Salesforce contract lapse and signed a ~\$9M/yr deal for **C3 AI** correspondence software (via Carahsoft), and ramped **Palantir** (a ~\$500M acreage-reporting deal). Separately, **Monday.com** guided Q3 revenue growth down to 16–17% with net revenue retention slipping to 108%; shares -9%.
- **Why:** Buyers are consolidating software spend around the best AI tools, pressuring incumbents. Salesforce stock is -25% YTD; C3 AI -23% YTD (but the USDA win is a needed proof point). Enterprise-software health is under intense scrutiny as the sector transitions to AI.
- **When:** Reported 11 Aug (USDA); Monday.com earnings 10 Aug.
- **Which:** Salesforce (CRM), C3 AI (AI), Palantir (PLTR), Monday.com (MNDY).
- **How:** AI raises customer expectations (some firms now build their own CRM with Claude Code); Salesforce is countering with “forward-deployed engineers” and Agentforce (AI revenue spiked in the April quarter).
- **Link:** [Agriculture Dept. Taps C3 AI to Trim Salesforce Footprint](#) · [Monday.com Projects Q3 Slowdown](#)

10. AI/VC capital keeps flowing: Craft, Anton Levy, Trajectory, Team8

- **What:** **Craft Ventures** (David Sacks) is targeting **\$1B** for its first post-White-House fund (LP total >\$4B). Ex-General Atlantic **Anton Levy** raised **>\$1.1B** for a debut fund. **Trajectory** (ex-Google/Apple founders) raised **\$40M at a \$300M valuation** led by Sequoia (with Nvidia and Bessemer). Israeli seed firm **Team8** raised \$365M and already exited Koi (sold to Palo Alto Networks for ~\$400M).
 - **Why:** First-time and AI-focused managers are still able to raise large sums in a challenging fundraising environment — a sign capital continues to chase AI infrastructure, tooling and open-source customisation. Israel remains a hot M&A/exit market (post Wiz/Armis deals).
 - **When:** All reported 10–11 Aug.
 - **Which:** Sequoia, Nvidia (NVDA), Bessemer, General Atlantic, Team8; Palo Alto Networks (PANW) as acquirer; read-through to model-customisation peers (Applied Compute, Thinking Machines).
 - **How:** Funds concentrate on Series A+ and open-source model customisation/“harness” tooling — the emerging middle layer between frontier labs and enterprise deployment.
 - **Link:** [Sacks' Craft Targets \\$1B First Fund](#) · [Trajectory Raises From Sequoia](#)
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Overall Market Trend, Development & Sentiment

Trend — “vendor-financed super-cycle.” The defining development of the day is the institutionalisation of AI-infrastructure financing. Nvidia’s \$500B alliance with Apollo/BlackRock/Blackstone/Brookfield/Goldman/KKR, plus the Anthropic–Macquarie–GIC JV, show private credit and sovereign wealth stepping in to fund a build-out that is too

large for corporate balance sheets alone. This extends the cycle but increases interconnection: Nvidia is now simultaneously the supplier, an equity holder and a partial guarantor of demand.

Development — the open-source front widens. Nvidia (Nemotron 4) and Meta (Muse Spark 1.2 / Muse Glimmer) both leaned harder into open models, framed partly as a US-vs-China strategic contest. This pressures closed-model economics and the “middle layer” (model-customisation startups like Trajectory, Applied Compute) is attracting capital as enterprises seek cheaper, tailored open models.

Sentiment — bullish tape, bearish undertow. Markets are still paying up for growth: CoreWeave +13% after hours despite a \$5.7B burn; Intel able to place \$15B after a 175% run. But the commentary tone from The Information is skeptical — dismantling CoreWeave’s adjusted EBITDA, flagging Kalshi’s serial fundraising, and highlighting Salesforce’s/Monday.com’s AI-transition strain. The market is beginning to differentiate between AI **share-gainers** (Nvidia, Palantir, C3 in pockets, Intel’s turnaround) and AI **margin-casualties** (legacy enterprise SaaS).

Key Questions & Risks Being Asked

- **Circularity / vendor-financing risk:** How much of AI “demand” is genuinely third-party vs. underwritten by Nvidia’s own backstops? If Nvidia cosigns leases and guarantees buy-backs, its ~\$50B/quarter FCF and balance sheet become the system’s shock absorber — and its credit risk becomes a market-wide concern.
- **Neocloud cash economics:** Can CoreWeave (and peers) ever convert 100%+ growth into positive free cash flow once capex normalises, given persistent D&A and rising interest? “Adjusted EBITDA” masks the leverage.
- **Prediction-market durability:** Is Kalshi’s World-Cup-driven surge structural or event-cyclical, and can it reach profitability before marketing spend and state taxes catch up — especially while raising every ~3 months?
- **Enterprise SaaS disruption:** Is USDA/Monday.com a one-off or the leading edge of budget consolidation away from Salesforce toward AI-native tools and DIY (Claude Code-built) apps? Salesforce -25% YTD suggests the market is pricing real risk.
- **OpenAI fragility:** Do the security pause (Astra), Apple litigation, and senior/robotics departures threaten the IPO narrative, or are they noise against 1B WAU and re-accelerating revenue?
- **Open-source channel conflict:** Does Nvidia competing with its own model-maker customers (Nemotron 4) risk its ecosystem relationships? Does Meta’s open-weight push commoditise frontier model pricing?

Risks to Monitor

1. **Concentration & credit risk at Nvidia** from backstop commitments across the \$500B alliance.
2. **Refinancing/rate risk** for capex-heavy neoclouds (CoreWeave) if AI demand or financing conditions soften.

3. **Multiple compression in legacy SaaS** (CRM, MNDY, ADBE-adjacent) as AI reshapes seat-based pricing and NRR.
 4. **Regulatory/security** overhang on frontier labs (OpenAI Astra pause; DoD/data-privacy tensions).
 5. **Private-market valuation air-pocket** if serial raisers (Kalshi) or richly-valued customisation startups stumble.
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Potential Investment Implications (companies directly mentioned)

Informational only — not investment advice. I am not a financial adviser; do your own due diligence.

Public equities

- **Nvidia (NVDA):** Central beneficiary of the \$500B alliance and both open-source and neocloud demand — but now also carrying backstop/credit risk and potential channel conflict with Nemotron 4. Watch for disclosure of guarantee exposure. Net: demand tailwind, rising tail-risk to monitor.
- **CoreWeave (CRWV):** High-beta AI-infrastructure proxy; strong revenue but \$5.7B burn and heavy leverage. Positive tape, but the free-cash-flow question is unresolved — a “show-me” name.
- **Intel (INTC):** Turnaround gathering pace (DC&AI +59%, CPU shortage, packaging traction); \$15B raise is dilutive short-term but funds expansion. Momentum name with execution risk.
- **Salesforce (CRM):** -25% YTD; USDA footprint reduction and DIY-CRM threat are sentiment negatives, partly offset by Agentforce traction and forward-deployed engineers. Contested — watch NRR and Agentforce ARR.
- **C3 AI (AI):** USDA win is a needed proof point after a brutal quarter (revenue -50%+, -23% YTD). Small, volatile; single contracts move the story.
- **Palantir (PLTR):** Continues to win large government AI mandates (USDA ~\$500M) — structural share-gainer, though valuation is demanding.
- **Monday.com (MNDY):** Guided-down Q3 (16–17% growth) and slipping NRR (–108%); emblematic of SaaS AI-transition risk. Cautious.
- **Meta (META):** Open-sourcing Muse Spark 1.2/Glimmer strengthens ecosystem and US-vs-China positioning; watch monetisation and capex intensity.
- **Amazon (AMZN) / Microsoft (MSFT) / Apple (AAPL):** OpenAI backers/partners and litigants; exposure to OpenAI’s trajectory (AMZN just added \$35B; MSFT’s homegrown AI chip showing signs of life; AAPL in active OpenAI litigation).
- **Enablers/lenders:** Apollo (APO), BlackRock (BLK), Blackstone (BX), Brookfield (BN), Goldman Sachs (GS), KKR (KKR), Macquarie (MQG.AX) — new fee/asset streams from AI-infrastructure credit; carry the counterparty risk if projects underperform.
- **Palo Alto Networks (PANW):** Acquirer of Israeli AI-security startup Koi (~\$400M) — continued roll-up of AI-native security.

- **Adjacent read-throughs:** TSMC (TSM), AMD (AMD) on the chip axis; DraftKings (DKNG), Flutter (FLUT), Robinhood (HOOD) on Kalshi's prediction-market momentum.

Private / pre-IPO to watch

- **OpenAI** (\$852B valuation; ~1B WAU; secondary liquidity ~\$16B) — IPO-track but with rising governance/security scrutiny.
 - **Anthropic** — off-balance-sheet compute financing (Theseus) supports a 10GW ambition; IPO candidate.
 - **Kalshi** (\$40B target) — hyper-growth, capital-hungry.
 - **OnlyFans** — Architect Capital's 16% stake at just north of \$3B; IPO ambitions and new financial products flagged.
 - **Model-customisation layer** — Trajectory (\$300M, Sequoia/Nvidia), Applied Compute (in talks at ~\$3B), Thinking Machines — the emerging enterprise open-source middleware.
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Also Noted (In Other News)

- **Manus** said it will “soon return to operating as an independent company,” unwinding its Meta acquisition after a Chinese-government order.
 - **Brad Lightcap**, OpenAI special-projects lead and former COO, is departing.
 - **xAI/“SpaceXAI”** released an AI agent, **Grok Bot**, co-developed with Cursor.
 - **Sony + TSMC** to invest \$6.3B in an image-sensor JV in Japan (prior day).
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